could not be fully carried out from Sittwe northwards, thus affecting ten out of Rakhine State's seventeen townships.

The census results proclaimed an estimated total population of over three million inhabitants, making Rakhine State the second-most populated ethnic state after Shan State. Of the total, nearly 2.1 million were enumerated, however an estimated 1,090,000 were not (MoIP 2015, p. 9).[18] It is believed these were largely Rohingya, or 'Bengalis', without citizenship. The government had previously committed to allow self-identification as Rohingya as a response to the question on ethnicity in the census questionnaire. Following pressure from Buddhist nationalist groups, this possibility was revoked just prior to the start of the count. This last-minute decision led to a variation in the enumeration practice across the townships concerned, and households where people decided to self-identify as Rohingya were not taken into account. The disputes around this led to new outbreaks of violence in Sittwe.

The term Rohingya — also used by international advocacy groups to speak of Muslims in Rakhine State — has gained more weight in recent years. Before the violence of 2012, it was mainly significant for Muslims in the northern parts of the state, but less so for those who were more integrated in Sittwe and in central townships. While for some Muslims in Rakhine State this term is still not the label of choice, its use has become more important for many and helps to forge more of a political identity (see ICG 2014, p. 23). For the ethnic Rakhine as much as for the union government, the term Rohingya is unacceptable, and the very existence of a Rohingya group in Myanmar is denied. Instead, most people in Myanmar use the term 'Bengali' which clearly carries connotations of Muslims as foreigners whose citizenship status should be rightfully denied, or at least verified.[19]

The lack of a compromise term such as 'Rakhine Muslim' rendered the 2014 census and pilot citizenship verification impossible to execute fully, or at least very difficult to implement. From mid-2014, the government implemented a voluntary pilot citizenship verification process in Myebon township. The ethnic Rakhine thought this would end allegedly illicit Muslim claims to citizenship. However, more applicants obtained at least 'naturalized' if not full citizenship than were expected.[20] The process was stopped (or at least did not proceed to other townships) over this controversy and resumed in the beginning of 2015, but with few applications. In informal conversations, Ministry of Immigration and